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Scope Covering Systems

Abstract

A scope cover can include a flexible fabric shell, a strap coupled to the flexible fabric shell that can secure the flexible fabric shell to the scope. An area of the interior surface of the flexible fabric shell can minimize or eliminate scratching of the objected lens of the scope. A method of minimizing abrasion to a scratch-sensitive surface of the scope is also described.

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Background/Summary

PRIORITY DATA [0001] This application is a continuation of U.S. patent application Ser. No. 18/659,836, which is a continuation of U.S. patent application Ser. No. 18/139,276, filed Apr. 25, 2023, which is a continuation of U.S. patent application Ser. No. 17/411,991, filed Aug. 25, 2021, which is a continuation of U.S. patent application Ser. No. 16/932,646, filed Jul. 17, 2020, which is a continuation of U.S. patent application Ser. No. 16/512,275, filed Jul. 15, 2019, which is a continuation of U.S. patent application Ser. No. 15/948,906, filed Apr. 9, 2018, which is a continuation of U.S. patent application Ser. No. 15/349,865, filed Nov. 11, 2016, which claims the benefit of U.S. Provisional Patent Application Ser. Nos. 62/254,125, filed on Nov. 11, 2015 and 62/378,138, filed on Aug. 22, 2016, each of which is incorporated herein by reference.

BACKGROUND

[0002] Telescopes are optical devices that can increase a user's ability to view remote objects. These optical devices have been found to be particularly useful in astronomy because they can be adapted to receive and focus a variety of wavelengths of electromagnetic radiation to extend the amount of information that can be collected by a user beyond the visible spectrum. However, even within the visible spectrum, telescopes can be very useful for a variety of other uses such as military and other tactical operations, animal tracking, hunting, and the like.

SUMMARY

[0003] The present disclosure provides scope covers or scope covering systems that can include a flexible fabric shell having an interior surface defining an interior cavity and an exterior surface opposite the interior surface. The flexible fabric shell can be adapted for placement of a scope within the interior cavity via an expandable and contractible opening in the flexible fabric shell. A strap can be coupled to the flexible fabric shell, which can be configured to secure the flexible fabric shell to the scope. An area of the interior surface of the flexible fabric shell can minimize or eliminate scratching of the eyepiece and/or objective lens of the scope.

[0004] A method of minimizing abrasion to a scratch-sensitive surface of a scope is also described herein. The method can include inserting the scope into an interior cavity of a flexible fabric shell via an expandable and contractible opening, said interior cavity being defined by an interior surface of the flexible fabric shell. The interior surface can include an area that minimizes or eliminates scratching of the scratch-sensitive surface.

[0005] There has thus been outlined, rather broadly, the more important features of the invention so that the detailed description thereof that follows may be better understood, and so that the present contribution to the art may be better appreciated. Other features of the present invention will become clearer from the following detailed description of the invention, taken with the accompanying drawings and claims, or may be learned by the practice of the invention.

Description

BRIEF DESCRIPTION OF THE DRAWINGS

[0006] FIG. 1 illustrates a view of an exterior surface of a scope cover, in accordance with examples of the current disclosure.

[0007] FIG. 2 illustrates a view of an interior surface of a scope cover, in accordance with examples of the current disclosure.

[0008] FIG. 3 illustrates a view of an exterior surface of a closable storage pouch for a scope cover, in accordance with examples of the current disclosure.

[0009] FIG. 4 illustrates a view of an interior surface of a closable storage pouch for a scope cover, in accordance with examples of the current disclosure.

[0010] These drawings are provided to illustrate various aspects of the invention and are not intended to be limiting of the scope in terms of dimensions, materials, configurations, arrangements or proportions unless otherwise limited by the claims.

DETAILED DESCRIPTION

[0011] While these exemplary embodiments are described in sufficient detail to enable those skilled in the art to practice the invention, it should be understood that other embodiments may be realized and that various changes to the invention may be made without departing from the spirit and scope of the present invention. Thus, the following more detailed description of the embodiments of the present invention is not intended to limit the scope of the invention, as claimed, but is presented for purposes of illustration only and not limitation to describe the features and characteristics of the present invention, to set forth the best mode of operation of the invention, and to sufficiently enable one skilled in the art to practice the invention. Accordingly, the scope of the present invention is to be defined solely by the appended claims.

Definitions

[0012] In describing and claiming the present invention, the following terminology will be used.

[0013] The singular forms “a,” “an,” and “the” include plural referents unless the context clearly dictates otherwise. Thus, for example, reference to “a particle” includes reference to one or more of such materials and reference to “subjecting” refers to one or more such steps.

[0014] As used herein with respect to an identified property or circumstance, “substantially” refers to a degree of deviation that is sufficiently small so as to not measurably detract from the identified property or circumstance. The exact degree of deviation allowable may in some cases depend on the specific context.

[0015] As used herein, “adjacent” refers to the proximity of two structures or elements.

Particularly, elements that are identified as being “adjacent” may be either abutting or connected. Such elements may also be near or close to each other without necessarily contacting each other. The exact degree of proximity may in some cases depend on the specific context.

[0016] As used herein, a plurality of items, structural elements, compositional elements, and/or materials may be presented in a common list for convenience. However, these lists should be construed as though each member of the list is individually identified as a separate and unique member. Thus, no individual member of such list should be construed as a de facto equivalent of any other member of the same list solely based on their presentation in a common group without indications to the contrary.

[0017] Concentrations, amounts, and other numerical data may be presented herein in a range format. It is to be understood that such range format is used merely for convenience and brevity and should be interpreted flexibly to include not only the numerical values explicitly recited as the limits of the range, but also to include all the individual numerical values or sub-ranges encompassed within that range as if each numerical value and sub-range is explicitly recited. For example, a numerical range of about 1 to about 4.5 should be interpreted to include not only the explicitly recited limits of 1 to about 4.5, but also to include individual numerals such as 2, 3, 4, and sub-ranges such as 1 to 3, 2 to 4, etc. The same principle applies to ranges reciting only one numerical value, such as “less than about 4.5,” which should be interpreted to include all of the above-recited values and ranges. Further, such an interpretation should apply regardless of the breadth of the range or the characteristic being described.

[0018] Any steps recited in any method or process claims may be executed in any order and are not

limited to the order presented in the claims. Means-plus-function or step-plus-function limitations will only be employed where for a specific claim limitation all of the following conditions are present in that limitation: a) “means for” or “step for” is expressly recited; and b) a corresponding function is expressly recited. The structure, material or acts that support the means-plus function are expressly recited in the description herein. Accordingly, the scope of the invention should be determined solely by the appended claims and their legal equivalents, rather than by the descriptions and examples given herein.

[0019] In this disclosure, “comprises,” “comprising,” “containing” and “having” and the like can have the meaning ascribed to them in U.S. Patent law and can mean “includes,” “including,” and the like, and are generally interpreted to be open ended terms. The terms “consisting of” or “consists of” are closed terms, and include only the components, structures, steps, or the like specifically listed in conjunction with such terms, as well as that which is in accordance with U.S. Patent law. “Consisting essentially of” or “consists essentially of” have the meaning generally ascribed to them by U.S. Patent law. In particular, such terms are generally closed terms, with the exception of allowing inclusion of additional items, materials, components, steps, or elements, that do not materially affect the basic and novel characteristics or function of the item(s) used in connection therewith. For example, trace elements present in a composition, but not affecting the compositions nature or characteristics would be permissible if present under the “consisting essentially of” language, even though not expressly recited in a list of items following such terminology. When using an open ended term, like “comprising” or “including,” it is understood that direct support should be afforded also to “consisting essentially of” language as well as “consisting of” language as if stated explicitly and vice versa.

Scope Covering Systems

[0020] An initial overview of technology embodiments is provided below and specific technology embodiments are then described in further detail. This initial summary is intended to aid readers in understanding the technology more quickly, but is not intended to identify key or essential features of the technology, nor is it intended to limit the scope of the claimed subject matter.

[0021] A scope cover or scope covering system can include a flexible fabric shell having an interior surface defining an interior cavity and an exterior surface opposite the interior surface. The flexible fabric shell can be adapted for placement of a scope within the interior cavity via an expandable and contractible opening in the flexible fabric shell. A strap can be coupled to the flexible fabric shell, which can be configured to secure the flexible fabric shell to the scope. An area of the interior surface of the flexible fabric shell can minimize or eliminate scratching of the objective lenses of the scope.

[0022] A method of minimizing abrasion to a scratch-sensitive surface of a scope is also described herein. The method can include inserting the scope into an interior cavity of a flexible fabric shell via an expandable and contractible opening, said interior cavity being defined by an interior surface of the flexible fabric shell. The interior surface can include an area that minimizes or eliminates scratching of the scratch-sensitive surface.

[0023] It is noted that when discussing a scope cover or a method of minimizing abrasion to a scratch-sensitive surface of a scope, each of these discussions can be considered applicable to each of these examples, whether or not they are explicitly discussed in the context of that particular example. Thus, for example, in discussing a scope cover, features related to the scope cover can also be applicable to the method of minimizing abrasion to a scratch-sensitive surface of a scope, and vice versa.

[0024] With this initial overview in mind, the scope covers of the current disclosure will be described in more detail. One example of a scope cover **100** is illustrated in FIGS. **1** and **2**. The scope cover **100** can include a flexible fabric shell **110**. The flexible fabric shell can be made of a variety of materials. Typically, any soft, flexible material can be used. Non-limiting examples can include leather, neoprene, neogreen, lycra, thermocline, rubber, polyester, polyamide, polyethylene,

polypropylene, cotton, silk, wool, or combinations thereof.

[0025] The flexible fabric shell **110** can have an interior surface **120** defining an interior cavity **122** and an exterior surface **124** opposite the interior surface **120**. The interior surface and the exterior surface can be made of the same material or different materials. In some examples, the interior surface can be made of, include, and/or be lined with a material that minimizes or eliminates scratching of the eyepiece, objective lens, and/or other surface of a scope. In other examples, at least a portion or an area of the interior surface can be made of, include, and/or be lined with a material that minimizes or eliminates scratching of the eyepiece, objective lens, and/or other surface of a scope. In some examples, the portion or area of the interior surface that is made of, includes, and/or is lined with the scratch-minimizing material can include an area that is intended or designed to interface with an eyepiece, an objective lens, and/or other scratch-sensitive surface of a scope.

[0026] Generally, the scratch-minimizing material, or the material that minimizes or eliminates scratching, can include any soft, non-abrasive material. Non-limiting examples can include cotton, chamois, polyvinyl alcohol, polyester, polyethylene, polyamide, or a combination thereof. In some examples, the scratch-minimizing material can be a microfiber material. In some examples, the microfiber material can be made of polyester or a blend of polyester and polyamide. In some examples, the microfiber material can be a split microfiber material, such that all or a majority of the individual microfiber filaments are split into multi-stranded filaments.

[0027] In some examples, a tab, handle, or other gripping feature can be positioned on or coupled to the exterior surface of the flexible fabric shell. This can be done for a number of reasons. For example, the tab handle, or other gripping feature can be positioned opposite an area made of, including, and/or lined with the scratch-minimizing material. Thus, a user can grasp the tab or other gripping feature coupled to the exterior surface of the flexible fabric shell and manipulate the scratch-minimizing material disposed opposite the gripping feature to clean an eyepiece, an objective lens, etc. of a scope.

[0028] In another example, the tab, handle, or other gripping feature can be posited at a lens end or an eyepiece end of the scope cover to facilitate placement of the scope cover on the scope, such as gripping feature **180** illustrated in FIG. 1. Where this kind of tab, handle, or gripping feature is used, the lens side of the scope cover can be placed over the objective lens end of the scope and the user can pull on the gripping feature **180** to position the eyepiece side of the scope cover over the eyepiece end of the scope, as is partially illustrated in FIG. 1, or vice versa. The tab, handle, or other gripping feature can be made out of a variety of materials. Non-limiting examples can include leather, neoprene, neogreen, lycra, thermocline, rubber, polyester, polyamide, polyethylene, polypropylene, cotton, silk, wool, or a combination thereof.

[0029] As illustrated in FIG. 1, the flexible fabric shell **110** can be adapted for placement of a scope, such as scope **170**, within the interior cavity **122** via an expandable and contractible opening **130** in the flexible fabric shell **110**. As there are many different sizes of scopes, the flexible fabric shell can be made to accommodate a variety of sizes of scopes. In some examples, the flexible fabric shell can be a universal shell that is adapted to accommodate all or most sizes of scopes. In other examples, the flexible fabric shell can be made in a variety of sizes to accommodate different ranges of scope sizes. In some examples, the flexible fabric shell can be made of a size and shape to accommodate a hunting scope that is adapted to be mountable to a firearm. In another example, the flexible fabric shell can be made of a size and shape to accommodate a spotting scope that is not adapted to be mountable to a firearm, but can be adapted to be mountable to a tripod or other suitable support structure or device. Because the scopes are typically considerably longer than they are wide, the scope cover can also be considerably longer than it is wide. For example, in some cases, the scope cover can have a length to width ratio of from 8:1 or 7:1 to 3:1 or 2:1 in an unstretched state. In other examples, the scope cover can have a length to width ratio of from 6:1 or 5:1 to 3:1 or 2:1 in an unstretched state.

[0030] It is noted that the flexible fabric shell can accommodate a plurality of sizes of scopes for a number of reasons. For example, the flexible fabric shell can be made of a stretchable material. When the flexible fabric shell is made of a stretchable material, it can be stretched to cover larger sized scopes, while being able to accommodate smaller sized scopes without significant stretching. Further, whether the flexible fabric shell is stretchable or not, the flexible fabric shell can include an expandable and contractible opening, such as opening **130**. Thus, the expandable and contractible opening can be expanded to let out or contracted to draw in the flexible fabric shell to adjust a volume of the interior cavity to a greater or lesser volume, as desired. The expandable and contractible opening can include a variety of features to facilitate expansion and/or contraction of the opening. Non-limiting examples can include an elastomeric band, a drawstring, a cinch, a strap, a zipper, or a combination thereof.

[0031] As illustrated in FIGS. **1** and **2**, a strap **140** can be coupled to the flexible fabric shell **110**. The strap can be configured to secure the flexible fabric shell **110** to a scope, such as scope **170**. As illustrated in FIGS. **1** and **2**, in some examples, the strap can be oriented to cross the expandable and contractible opening laterally. Further, as illustrated in FIGS. **1** and **2**, the strap **140** can include two strap segments. Each of the strap segments is attached to the flexible fabric shell at opposite lateral sides of the expandable and contractible opening. Additionally, in this example, each of the strap segments is coupled to the flexible fabric shell such that opposite ends of each of the strap segments are coupled at distinct locations (i.e. one end is coupled towards an eyepiece side of the flexible fabric shell and one end is coupled towards a lens side of the flexible fabric shell). As such, each of the strap segments forms an angular orientation terminating at a connecting feature such that when the two strap segments are connected, a cross-pattern is formed. The cross-pattern can be adjusted from nearly linear to perpendicular in either a longitudinal or latitudinal direction, as desired. In yet other examples, separate pairs of straps can also be used to form the same cross patterns. For example, one or more pairs of strap segments can connect across the expandable and contractible opening in a linear manner, either laterally, longitudinally, or diagonally. In other examples, the straps can be parallel, rather than crossing. In yet other examples, one or more straps can be parallel and can be crossed by one or more non-parallel straps. In yet another specific example, the strap can be coupled to flexible fabric shell such that a first end or terminus of the strap or strap segment is coupled to the flexible fabric shell at a position more proximate the eyepiece side of the flexible fabric shell than a second end or terminus of the strap or strap segment.

[0032] The straps can be made of a variety of materials. Non-limiting examples can include leather, polyester, polyethylene, polypropylene, polyamide, ethylene vinyl acetate, rubber, neoprene, neogreen, lycra, thermocline, cotton, silk, wool, or a combination thereof.

[0033] A number of connecting features can be used to connect individual strap segments. While the example illustrated in FIGS. **1** and **2** is a buckle, the individual strap segments can be connected via a buckle, a snap, a hook and loop fastener, a button, a magnet, the like, or a combination thereof. In some examples, the strap does not include a connecting feature, but is coupled to the flexible fabric shell at substantially opposite sides of the expandable and contractible opening.

[0034] In some examples, a closeable storage pouch or container can be attached to the flexible fabric shell to store the flexible fabric shell when not in use. An example of a closeable storage pouch **200** is illustrated in FIGS. **3** and **4**. The closeable storage pouch **200** can have a body **215** of flexible or rigid material. As illustrated in FIGS. **3** and **4**, the body **215** of the closeable storage pouch **200** is made of a soft, flexible material, such as a material used to make the flexible fabric shell of the scope cover. However, in other examples, the closeable storage pouch can be made of a more rigid material, such as leather, polyethylene, polypropylene, polyamide, aluminum, tin, the like, or combinations thereof. In some examples, the closeable storage container can include a rigid material inserted within or lined with a more flexible material. As will be recognized by one skilled in the art, in some examples, the same materials can be made soft and flexible or hard and rigid

depending on the molecular weight, coordination, crosslinking, weave, or other features of the particular material.

[0035] The closeable storage pouch can also include an attachment feature **250** to facilitate attachment of the closeable storage pouch to a user's clothing, gear, or the like. Such attachment features can include a clip, clasp, clamp, strap, buckle, snap, hook and loop fastener, button, magnet, the like, or combinations thereof.

[0036] Additionally, the closeable storage pouch can be closeable via a variety of enclosing features, such as enclosing feature **260**. Non-limiting examples of enclosing features can include a foldable flap, such as the foldable flap illustrated in FIG. **3**, for example, a zipper, a hook and loop fastener, a snap, a button, a clip, a kiss lock, a magnet, the like, or combinations thereof.

[0037] In some examples, as illustrated in FIG. **4**, a soft cleaning material **218** can be attached to an interior surface of the closeable storage pouch **200**. The soft cleaning material can be made of a variety of materials, such as cotton, chamois, polyvinyl alcohol, polyester, polyethylene, polypropylene, polyamide, or a combination thereof, for example. In one specific example, the soft cleaning material can be a microfiber material. In some examples, the microfiber material can be made of polyester or a blend of polyester and polyamide. In some examples, the microfiber material can be a split microfiber material, such that all or a majority of the individual microfiber filaments are split into multi-stranded filaments.

[0038] Additionally, in some examples, the closeable storage pouch **200** can include a coupling feature **225** for coupling the closeable storage pouch **200** to the flexible fabric shell of the scope cover. In some examples, the coupling feature **225** can be permanently coupled to both the closeable storage pouch **200** and the flexible fabric shell. In other examples, the coupling feature can be removably coupleable to the closeable storage pouch and/or the flexible fabric shell. Where the coupling feature is removably coupleable to the closeable storage pouch and/or the flexible fabric shell, the coupling feature can be removably coupleable via a buckle, a magnet, a clip, a clamp, a snap, a strap, the like, or a combination thereof. In some examples, the coupling feature can be coupled at an exterior surface of the closeable storage container. In other examples, the coupling feature can be coupled at an interior surface of the closeable storage container.

[0039] In some examples, where the scope cover includes a closeable storage pouch, the closeable storage pouch can be storable against either the interior surface or the exterior surface of the flexible fabric shell. For example, the flexible fabric shell and/or the closeable storage pouch can include a pouch, pocket, clasp, snap, hook and loop fastener, button, clip, clamp, buckle, magnet, the like or combination thereof to store the closeable storage pouch against an exterior or interior surface of the flexible fabric shell when the closeable storage pouch is not in use. Alternatively, as described above, the closeable storage pouch can be removably coupleable to the flexible fabric shell so it can be removed from the flexible fabric shell when not in use.

[0040] A method of minimizing abrasion to a scratch-sensitive surface of a scope is also described herein. The method can include inserting the scope into an interior cavity of a flexible fabric shell via an expandable and contractible opening. The interior cavity can be defined by an interior surface of the flexible fabric shell. The interior surface can include an area that minimizes or eliminates scratching the scratch-sensitive surface. In some examples, the area that minimizes or eliminates scratching of the scratch-sensitive surface can cover the entire interior surface. In another example, the area that minimizes or eliminates scratching of the scratch-sensitive surface can cover a portion of the interior surface that is intended, designed, or configured to interface with the scratch-sensitive surface. In some examples, the scratch-sensitive surface of the scope can include an objective lens, an eyepiece, or both.

[0041] The foregoing detailed description describes the invention with reference to specific exemplary embodiments. However, it will be appreciated that various modifications and changes can be made without departing from the scope of the present invention as set forth in the appended claims. The detailed description and accompanying drawings are to be regarded as merely

illustrative, rather than as restrictive, and all such modifications or changes, if any, are intended to fall within the scope of the present invention as described and set forth herein.

Claims

1. A scope cover, comprising: a flexible fabric shell having an interior surface defining an interior cavity, and an exterior surface opposite the interior surface, the flexible fabric shell being adapted for placement of a scope within the interior cavity via an expandable and contractible opening in the flexible fabric shell; a strap coupled to the flexible fabric shell, said strap being configured to secure the flexible fabric shell to the scope; and an area of the interior surface of the flexible fabric shell that minimizes or eliminates scratching of an objective lens of the scope.
2. The scope cover of claim 1, wherein the flexible fabric shell comprises a material selected from the group consisting of neoprene, neogreen, lycra, thermocline, rubber, polyesters, polyamides, polyethylenes, polypropylenes, cotton, silk, wool, or a combination thereof.
3. The scope cover of claim 1, further comprising an area of the interior surface of the flexible fabric shell that minimizes or eliminates scratching of the eyepiece of the scope.
4. The scope cover of claim 1, wherein the area of the interior surface of the flexible fabric shell that minimizes or eliminates scratching of the objective lens of the scope comprises a material selected from the group consisting of cotton, chamois, polyvinyl alcohol, polyester, polyethylene, polypropylene, polyamide, or a combination thereof.
5. The scope cover of claim 4, wherein the material is a microfiber material.
6. The scope cover of claim 1, wherein the area of the interior surface of the flexible fabric shell that minimizes or eliminates scratching of the objective lens of the scope covers the entire inner surface.
7. The scope cover of claim 1, wherein the area of the interior surface of the flexible fabric shell that minimizes or eliminates scratching of the objective lens of the scope covers a portion of the interior surface configured to interface with the objective lens of the scope.
8. The scope cover of claim 1, further comprising a tab coupled to the exterior surface, said tab being disposed proximate to the objective lens of the scope and opposite the area of the interior surface of the flexible fabric shell that minimizes or eliminates scratching of the objective lens of the scope.
9. The scope cover of claim 8, wherein the tab comprises a material selected from the group consisting of neoprene, neogreen, lycra, thermocline, rubber, polyesters, polyamides, polyethylenes, polypropylenes, cotton, silk, wool, or a combination thereof.
10. The scope cover of claim 1, wherein the expandable and contractible opening comprises at least one of an elastomeric band, a drawstring, a cinch, a strap, and a zipper.
11. The scope cover of claim 1, wherein the strap comprises a plurality of straps.
12. The scope cover of claim 1, wherein the strap comprises a material selected from the group consisting of leather, polyester, polyethylene, polypropylene, polyamide, ethylene vinyl acetate, rubber, neoprene, neogreen, lycra, thermocline, cotton, silk, wool, or a combination thereof.
13. The scope cover of claim 1, wherein the strap comprises two strap segments that are connectable via a buckle, a snap, a hook and loop fastener, a button, a magnet, or a combination thereof.
14. The scope cover of claim 1, further comprising a closeable storage pouch attached to the flexible fabric shell, said closeable storage pouch comprising a soft cleaning material attached to an interior surface of the closeable storage pouch, and an attachment feature configured to attach the closeable storage pouch to a user's gear.
15. The scope cover of claim 14, wherein the closeable storage pouch is storable against either the interior surface or the exterior surface of the flexible fabric shell via at least one of a pouch, a pocket, a clasp, a snap, a hook and loop fastener, a button, a clip, a clamp, a buckle, and a magnet.

- 16.** A method of minimizing abrasion to a scratch-sensitive surface of a scope, comprising: inserting the scope into an interior cavity of a flexible fabric shell via an expandable and contractible opening, said interior cavity being defined by an interior surface of the flexible fabric shell, the interior surface comprising an area that minimizes or eliminates scratching of the scratch-sensitive surface.
- 17.** The method of claim 16, wherein the area that minimizes or eliminates scratching of the scratch-sensitive surface covers the entire interior surface.
- 18.** The method of claim 16, wherein the area that minimizes or eliminates scratching of the scratch-sensitive surface covers a portion of the interior surface that is configured to interface with the scratch-sensitive surface.
- 19.** The method of claim 16, wherein the scratch-sensitive surface comprises at least one of an objective lens of the scope or an eyepiece of the scope.
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